

personality.

A musical prodigy

Frédéric François Chopin (Polish: Fryderyk Franciszek Szopen) was born at Zelazowa Wola, near Warsaw, where his French-born father, Nicolas, was tutor to the children of a local aristocrat. Six months later, the family moved to Warsaw, where Nicolas got a job teaching French—the second language of the Polish aristocracy—at the recently founded Lyceum. At this time, Poland was not an independent country. It had been fought over for much of the previous century and after the Napoleonic Wars ended in 1815 it effectively became part of the Russian Empire—a situation that fostered a strong movement for national freedom.